

Q.3b (20 marks): Briefly explain Formalism and Substantivism Debate in Anthropology and contemporary economic is...

4.b) Briefly explain Formalism and Substantivism Debate in Anthropology. How does the debate inform our understanding of contemporary economic issues such as globalization, poverty, and environmental sustainability? (20 marks)

Dr. Peter Beals and Hoijer, Economic Anthro.

studies production, distribution and exchange

and consumption systems as they are institutionalized in simple and modern societies.

Economic Anthropology further subdivided into two major schools → Formalists and Substantivists with their separate approaches for this

ORIGIN OF DEBATE

↳ Karel Polanyi's "The Great Transformation (1944)" introduced the substantivist revolution

↳ He borrowed the debate from Max Weber's concepts of formal rationality and substantivist rationality in sociology

DEBATE BETWEEN BOTH

Formalist

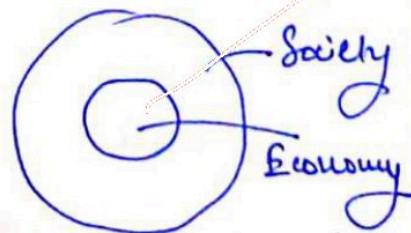
- Scholars: Raymond Firth, M. Hertzovitz, Schneider
- View - Societies should be studied with neoclassical economics using principles of demand and supply, profit and loss, rationality, market and trade → whether they are modern economies or Simple Societies

- Society is disembedded from economics



Substantivists

- Scholars - Polanyi, Maclure, Dalton
- view - Simple Societies' economies are based on kinship and thus all these principles fail to explain several practices among them
eg. Kogi Indians don't till with despite land scarcity as their ancestors teach them
- Economy of Simple Societies is embedded in their social matrix
- Karl Polanyi



Famous explanations by Sahlins in the following verses

→ "Money is to the west, what kinship is to the east"

→ "Indes are optimisers and not maximisers"

could very well explain following practices

Kukuru -
work for 4-5 hrs
a day - rest leisure
(by R. Komens)

dangerous
Kule vaye
(by Malinowski)

destruction
of valuable
by Borah
(Yang Boas)

Bishop's
shifting
cultivation

However, several new realities like globalisation, poverty and environmental sustainability have changed the scenario

→ Introduction of money and modern

market in tribal economy

eg. Gonds selling their hand made products digitally via e-commerce

→ Cultural impact

eg. Alcohol and drugs introduced in tribal hamlets - most of once addicted.

→ Global companies encroaching forest land leading to Industrial nomadism (MS Srinivas) → landless labor & fire hilt workers e.g. Sahariyas & Rajpoots, Mankidia, monkey catchers.

→ Climate change → increased vulnerabilities
Gaddi tribe losing pastures to carry ←
on their economic activities

Hence, older simple kinship based economies running on generalised reciprocities have now been introduced to the neoclassical economic principles as listed in beginning.

Thus Plattner says that any one approach either substantivist or formalist can't explain this complex transition.

Prattis → even modern economies have transactions without profit motive.

Thus, both approaches should be used judiciously to understand contemporary economic issues.

Follow
 structure
 of
 economy
 and focus
 points
 accordingly